Before you begin

Gambling: my diary and my life story

Keeping a diary

Buy a notebook or journal that you keep just for this programme. Start writing in it today, every day until your cohort begins, and keep going through the 33 days. You don't need to change anything yet: just notice, and write it down. Nobody else needs to read it.

Each time you gamble, or feel a strong urge to, write down:

- The time, and where you are (an app, a website, a venue).
- What you bet on, and how much.
- Whether you are alone, or who you are with.
- What you were doing just before.
- How you felt just before: stressed, bored, lonely, hopeful, under pressure about money.
- How strong the urge was, from 0 to 5, and whether you acted on it.

At the end of each day, write a few lines:

- How much time and money did I spend gambling today?
- Which urges did I let pass? Which felt hardest to resist, and why?
- What emotions sat underneath my gambling today?
- How did I feel after winning, and after losing?
- One thing I noticed about myself today.

My life story

Take your time with these. Write in your journal over a few days, as much or as little as feels right. There are no right answers: just be honest with yourself.

1. When did you first gamble? How old were you, where were you, and who were you with?

2. What was happening in your life at that time?

3. How long have you gambled? How has it changed over the years: times you gambled more, less, or stopped for a while?

4. What do you gamble on now (sport, casino apps, slots, cards, lottery, trading), how often, and how much?

5. What is gambling a replacement for? What does it give you that you don't get another way: excitement, escape, hope, belonging, a sense of control?

6. Which emotions most often lead you to gamble: stress, boredom, loneliness, worry about money, anger, sadness?

7. Who in your family gambled, or gambles? What did you learn about money and risk growing up?

8. What have you tried before to stop or cut down, and what did you learn from it?

9. What does gambling cost you: money, debt, time, sleep, relationships, trust, how you feel about yourself?

10. What has brought you to this group, now?

11. Who are you becoming? Describe a day in your life free of gambling.